

Anshu Gupta

Anshu Gupta (born ~1970s) founded Goonj in 1999, revolutionizing dignity-based development by treating clothing as a development resource for 27 states. Ramon Magsaysay Awardee (2015) known as "Clothing Man," his urban surplus → rural barter model aligns perfectly with your social innovation podcast.

Education

- Master's in Economics.
- Degree in Mass Communication.

Career

Freelance journalist writing on humanitarian issues; copywriter at Chaitra Leo Burnett; corporate roles at Power Grid Corporation, Escorts Communications. Quit corporate life (1998) to launch Goonj with wife Meenakshi using 67 personal clothing items; scaled to 3,500+ tonnes material/year across 4,000+ villages; founded Gram Swabhimaan for village self-respect restoration.

Awards & Recognition

- Ramon Magsaysay Award (2015) ("Nobel of Asia") for transforming India's giving culture.
- Schwab Foundation Social Entrepreneur (2012).
- Ashoka Fellow; World Bank Development Marketplace; Jamnalal Bajaj Fair Business Practices.

Anshu Gupta's Story

Early 1990s corporate life left Anshu disillusioned—journalism exposed disasters where aid ignored dignity: Uttarakhand flood women used sarees as tents, children wrapped in polythene. Met Habib Bhai (collected unclaimed corpses, used cloth for shrouds): "Clothing is first visible poverty sign—ignored because everyone has it." Realized urban India generates 1L+ tonnes unusable clothing yearly while rural development overlooked cloth.

Quit Escorts job (1999), convinced wife Meenakshi to donate 67 personal clothes from Sarita Vihar home—no office, no funding. Initial charity model failed: villages rejected "free handouts." Epiphany during Gujarat earthquake relief: gave saree to woman who built toilet instead. Born "Cloth for Work"—material as reward for community labor. Discovered rural women used ash/leaves during menstruation (tetanus deaths); Not Just a Piece of Cloth converted sarees to 2.5cr+ pads. Built parallel economy valuing rural sweat + urban waste equally, proving dignity multiplies development impact.



Leadership at GOONJ

Anshu pioneered "Cloth as Currency" ecosystem processing 3,500+ tonnes urban surplus annually into rural development catalyst: Cloth for Work (CFW) barter for infrastructure (bridges, wells, roads serving 4,000+ villages); Not Just a Piece of Cloth (NJPAC) produces 2.5cr+ sanitary pads from sarees, boosting school attendance 30%; School-to-School recycles urban stationery preventing slum dropouts.

Disaster response Rahat reaches govt-blind spots within 6 hours (Kashmir earthquake, Kerala floods); Green by Goonj upcycles scrap into 100+ products (jeans bags, tape mats) funding rural work. Launched SARRD—world's first cross-sector disaster alliance pre-committing resources for coordinated response. Gram Swabhimaan restores village self-respect via participatory assessment. Transformed 3M+ urban donors from charity to mindful giving; dignity lens redefined CSR/NGO models globally (WEF/UN replication).